

1,500 commercial pilot licences a year. CAPA India forecasts that the sector will require around 10,900 new pilots by 2030. In December 2024, a Ministry of Civil Aviation report submitted to the Lok Sabha showed that Indian airlines had 236 foreign pilots, a number that had tripled from 67 in March 2023. Air India Express alone accounted for 144 of these, following the induction of 35 Boeing 737 MAX aircraft, for which there were far too few Indian commanders with type ratings. The Level D Full Flight Simulators, mandatory for type ratings, are dominated by foreign manufacturers such as CAE of Canada, L3Harris of the United States, and Thales of France.

The dependency does not stop at the cockpit. It extends to the corner office. Every one of the big Indian carriers has, for the better part of three decades, had a foreign national at the helm. Pieter Elbers, a former Dutch CEO of KLM, served as the CEO of IndiGo until his resignation in March 2026, following the December crisis that led to flight cancellations. Air India has been led by Campbell Wilson, a New Zealander with 26 years at Singapore Airlines, since its privatisation; he announced his resignation in 2026, with the board yet to name a successor. IndiGo's incoming CEO, Willie Walsh—Irish and a former British Airways chief and most recently IATA Director General—will take over in August 2026. Before Wilson, the Tatas had initially offered the Air India role to Ilker Ayci, then chairman of Turkish Airlines, who turned it down amid controversies. The historical tally runs deeper: Wolfgang Prock-Schauer of Austria led both Jet Airways and GoAir; Nikos Kardassis, a Greek American, ran Jet Airways; Cornelis Vrieswijk,

a Dutchman, headed GoAir; and Phee Teik Yeoh of Singapore led Vistara.

Captain G.R. Gopinath, who founded Air Deccan, remarks that “if Indians can be CEOs of the world’s largest companies abroad, how is it that our own airlines cannot find leaders at home? The answer is that while we have thousands of pilots and aviation engineers, we simply do not have a large pool of aerospace and airline management professionals, a field that is quite complex.”

INDIGENISATION

To address this dependence, experts bat for building indigenous capacity. However, that does not

WHO POWERS INDIA'S AIRCRAFT?



CFM INTERNATIONAL
(GE + SAFRAN)
LEAP, over 72% of the
world new narrow body



GE AVIATION
GE90 on Air India's 777s



ROLLS-ROYCE
Trent XWB on A350s



PRATT & WHITNEY

**INDIAN
COMMERCIAL
JET ENGINES**
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mean that a domestic commercial aircraft would compete against the A320. Group Captain Chari points out three conditions for any significant indigenisation: a certification framework equivalent to those of the FAA and EASA; a capital financing approach that can sustain development cycles of 12 to 15 years; and a materials manufacturing ecosystem that produces aerospace-grade titanium and aluminium at scale.

If the reform efforts that began in 2020 continue, the domestic MRO share could rise from 14% to 30–40% over the next decade. Safran's LEAP engine MRO plant in Hyderabad, likely to go live by late 2026 with a capacity of 300 engine shop visits per annum, indicates that international OEMs have begun to invest in India's depth rather than just profit from it.

Adesh Nandal, an advocate at Jotwani Associates who advises on aviation law and policy, argues that the rebalancing is already underway. “The move to reduce GST on domestic MRO services from 18% to 5%, and to introduce a uniform IGST rate of 5% for aircraft parts and engines, is not cosmetic reform but structural,” he says. “GIFT City entities have leased hundreds of planes so far. Minimum Indian content and technology-transfer obligations can be built into next-generation airport contracts.”

India's aviation boom looks impressive, but it relies heavily on foreign systems and equipment. Although the government and airlines are aware of this dependence, current efforts to address it are not sufficient.

India's skies are full of aircraft, but much of the financial and strategic control behind them belongs to others. **BT**